

V2 Failure Stories

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	4-10 (optimal: 6-8)
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	V1 (Vulnerability Circle) recommended but not required	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Low vulnerability scores, fear of admitting mistakes, blame culture signals, low innovation/risk-taking indicators

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Fear of failure is a cortisol-driven response. When the brain associates failure with social punishment (criticism, loss of status, career consequences), the amygdala flags risk-taking as a threat. Over time, this creates teams that play it safe, hide mistakes, and avoid experimentation.

Sharing failure stories in a structured, safe context reverses this pattern. When someone shares a failure and receives acceptance rather than judgment, cortisol drops and oxytocin rises. The brain recategorises failure from 'threat' to 'survivable.' Repeated exposure to this reframing builds neural pathways that support risk-taking and honest reporting of problems.

The key mechanism is normalisation. When the manager and multiple team members share failures openly, the brain stops treating failure as an outlier event that singles you out and starts treating it as a shared human experience.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"We learn more from what goes wrong than from what goes right. But most teams bury their failures, which means they keep making the same mistakes and nobody dares try anything new. This exercise makes it normal to talk about what didn't work so we can actually learn from it."

Before You Begin

Materials

In-Person	Remote
Flipchart or whiteboard Markers Index cards (one per person) Timer	Miro board with pre-set story template sections Digital timer (shared screen) Private chat or DM function disabled during shares

	Camera on (recommended)
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PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY CHECK

Do NOT run this exercise if:

- A team member has recently experienced a significant, visible failure that has not been resolved (the exercise would feel targeted)
- There is an active blame culture where mistakes lead to consequences (the exercise will produce performative stories, not real ones)
- The manager has not prepared their own failure story to share first

If the team has not completed V1 (Vulnerability Circle), consider the trust level carefully. V2 asks people to share specific failures, which requires more trust than the general vulnerability sharing in V1.

Manager Self-Preparation

You go first. Prepare a professional failure story that follows this structure:

- What you were trying to do (the goal, not the context lecture)
- What went wrong (specific, not vague)
- What it cost (be honest about the impact, do not minimise)
- What you took from it (not a tidy lesson, but what actually changed in how you work)

CALIBRATION GUIDE

Too safe: "I once missed a deadline." (Too common, too low-stakes. Nobody learns anything.)

Right level: "I pushed a project decision through without consulting the team because I was sure I was right. It turned out I was missing critical information that two team members had. We lost three weeks of work and I had to rebuild trust with the people I'd overridden."

Too much: "I was nearly fired for..." (Shifts the tone from learning to crisis narrative.)

The Exercise**Phase 1: Opening and Framing (5 minutes)****WHAT TO SAY**

"Today I'm going to ask each of us to share a time we got something wrong at work. Not a small thing. Something that actually mattered. The goal is not to dwell on mistakes. The goal is to make it normal to talk about them, because teams that can do that catch problems earlier, learn faster, and take smarter risks."

"I'm going to go first. Then I'll give you a few minutes to think about your own story before we go round."

Phase 2: Manager Models (3-4 minutes)

Share your prepared failure story. Keep it to 90 seconds. Follow the four-part structure: goal, what went wrong, cost, what changed.

FACILITATION NOTE

Resist the urge to wrap your story with a redemption arc. "And then I learned to always consult my team and everything was better" kills the authenticity. End on what changed, honestly. If you still struggle with it sometimes, say so.

Phase 3: Individual Preparation (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Take five minutes to think about a professional failure you'd be willing to share. Use these four prompts: What were you trying to do? What went wrong? What did it cost? What did you take from it? Write it down for yourself. You'll decide how much detail you share out loud."

Give each person an index card with the four prompts pre-printed (or display on screen for remote). Writing forces specificity. Thinking alone often stays vague.

Phase 4: Sharing Round (20-25 minutes)

Invite volunteers. Do not go round-robin. Allow 2-3 minutes per story.

After each story, the manager's response:

5. Acknowledge: "Thank you. That's a real one."
6. Ask one follow-up (optional): "What's the thing you wish you'd done differently in the moment?" This invites reflection without judgment.
7. Do NOT: say "I had a similar experience" (makes it about you) or "At least you learned from it" (minimises the cost).
8. Invite the group briefly: "Does that connect with anyone else's experience?" Short responses only. This is not a group therapy session.

ENERGY MANAGEMENT

Stories 3-4 often dip in energy as the novelty wears off. If you notice this, after story 3, say: "I'm hearing a pattern here. Can anyone name what connects these stories?" This shifts from passive listening to active synthesis and re-engages the room.

Phase 5: Pattern Recognition (5-7 minutes)

This is where the individual stories become team learning. Do not skip this phase.

WHAT TO SAY

"Now I want us to look at what we just heard as a collection, not individual stories. What patterns do you notice? Are there common causes? Common pressures? Things that our team or our organisation does that makes these failures more likely?"

Write the patterns on the flipchart/Miro. Common ones: time pressure leading to shortcuts, not asking for help early enough, assumptions going unchallenged, information not reaching the right people.

Then the critical question:

WHAT TO SAY

"Looking at these patterns, which one is most alive for us right now? Which one are we most at risk of repeating?"

This question moves the exercise from reflection to prevention. It is the most valuable moment of the session.

Phase 6: Close (3 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"What happened here stays here, but the patterns don't have to. If you see one of these patterns showing up in our work, I want you to name it. You can say 'I think we're doing the thing' and everyone will know what that means. That's the goal: catching the pattern before it becomes the next failure story."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Someone shares a failure they clearly haven't processed (still angry, still blaming others)	Acknowledge without redirecting too sharply: "I can hear that this one still stings. Thank you for bringing it." Do not correct their framing in the group. If you hear blame rather than ownership, let it stand in the session. Address it privately afterward if needed. The group will notice the difference between this story and the others. That contrast is itself a learning moment.
Stories stay safe and inconsequential ("I once sent an email to the wrong person")	After 2-3 safe stories, recalibrate gently: "These are useful. Can I push us slightly? Think about a time when you made a decision that had real consequences. Something that changed how you work." If the group still stays surface, accept it. This is a trust signal. Run V1 first next time.

Someone shares a failure that implicates another person in the room	Redirect immediately: "Let's keep the focus on our own decisions and actions. What was the part that was in your control?" This reframes without shaming either party. Follow up privately with both people after the session.
The manager's own failure story falls flat (no reaction, awkward silence)	This usually means the story was either too safe or too polished. Do not try to fix it in the moment. Move to the preparation phase. For next time, recalibrate using the calibration guide.

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Stories become more specific and honest as the round progresses Someone says "I've never told anyone at work about this" The pattern recognition phase generates genuine debate rather than polite agreement
Within 1-2 weeks	A team member raises a problem or mistake in a meeting without waiting for it to escalate Language shifts: "I got this wrong" instead of "there was a problem with..." Someone references the patterns from the session in a work context
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Vulnerability scores increase Communication scores may also improve (failure sharing opens other honest conversations) Qualitative data shows language about learning, honesty, or mistakes
Red flags	If vulnerability scores drop or people seem more guarded after the session, the safety conditions may not have been met. Follow up individually. Ask: "How did that exercise land for you?"

Remote/Hybrid Adaptation

Element	Remote Modification
Preparation cards	Display the four-prompt structure on a shared screen. Ask people to write privately in a notebook, NOT in chat or a shared document.
Sharing round	Keep full group (no breakout rooms). The manager must be present for every share. Ask everyone to close other applications and focus.
Pattern recognition	Use Miro sticky notes for patterns instead of flipchart. This gives remote participants equal input (typing is faster than waiting for airtime).
Cameras	Strongly request cameras on for this session. Seeing faces during vulnerability matters.
Timing	Add 10 minutes. Online sharing rounds take longer because speakers

	pause more without physical feedback cues.
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Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	V1 builds the trust foundation that V2 requires. V2 focuses specifically on failure rather than general vulnerability.	Run V1 before V2 (2-4 weeks gap)
V7: Fear of Failure	V7 addresses the systemic conditions that create fear of failure. V2 addresses the personal experience of failure.	Complementary (run within same month)
V10: Respectful Disagreement	Failure stories often reveal moments where challenge or disagreement was needed but did not happen.	Run after V2
R2: From Ideas to Action	The pattern recognition phase in V2 generates insights that need action planning to become real change.	Complementary